

VALENCE ASYMMETRIES IN EXPLANATORY BELIEFS

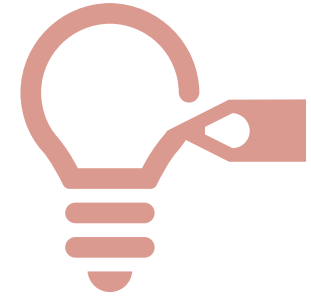


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Project EPIC

PLAN

1. Strange Beliefs and Why we adopt them
 2. But: Why do want to believe horrible things?
 3. My proposal: Believing What Resonates
 4. Interplay of Valences
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1. STRANGE BELIEFS



Biased Beliefs

Conspiracy Theory Beliefs

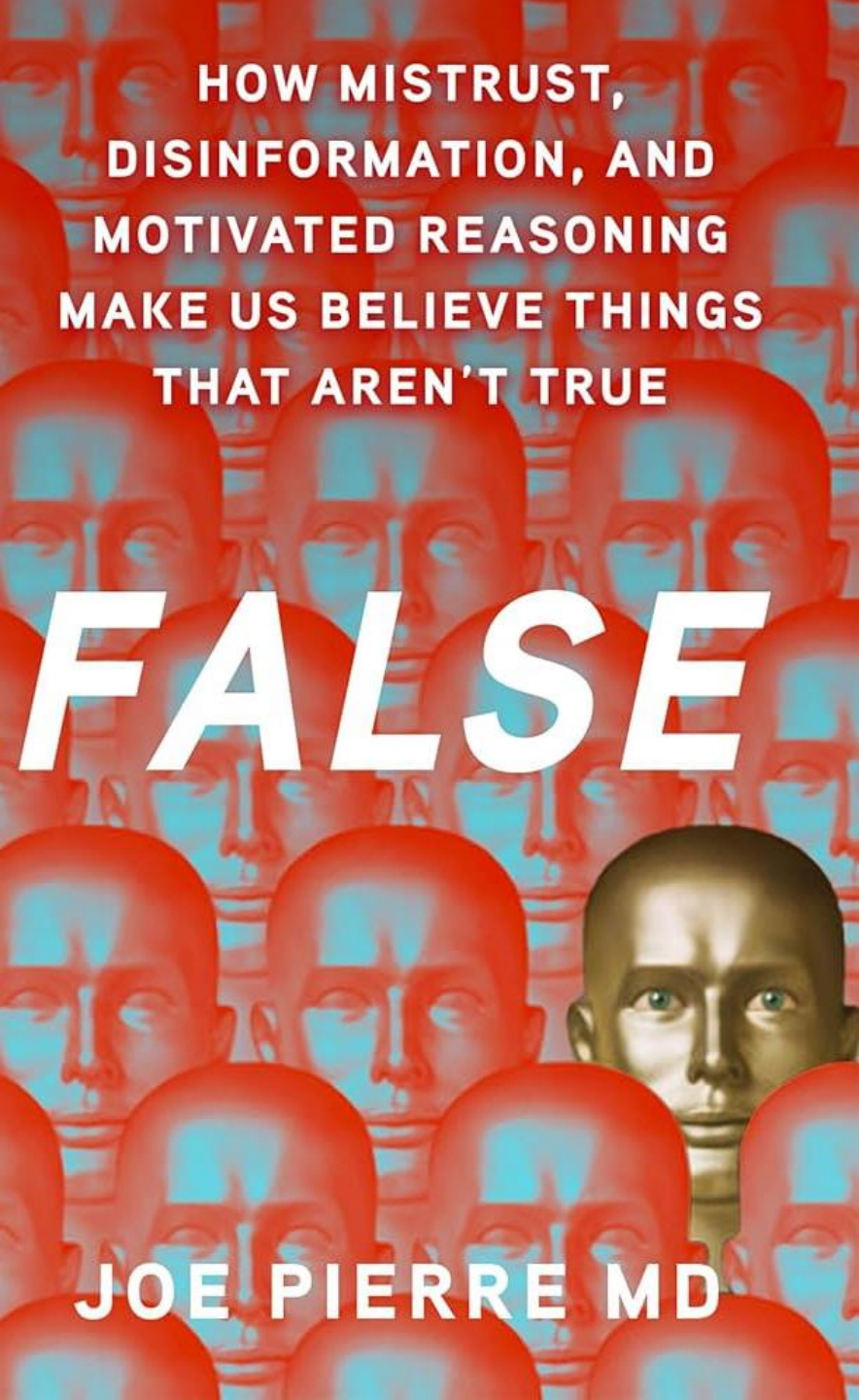
Delusional Beliefs

- Spectrum?
 - What is it that differs along the spectrum, and, why do the beliefs seem to get more and more unpleasant?
 - I don't think we have good answers to these questions.
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1. WHY WE ADOPT THEM

EVERYDAY IRRATIONAL BELIEFS:

- Biases
 - Optimism bias, confirmation bias, self-serving bias, in-group biases, stereotypes.
 - Motivated reasoning
 - “Information-sampling biases arise when individuals strategically alter which information they seek out and ignore in the interests of finding rationalizations for desired beliefs or avoiding evidence in tension with such desired beliefs. Information-processing biases arise when individuals interpret and process information in biased ways, and they include strategic variations in the time spent reasoning and deliberating, asymmetries in the standards required for accepting and rejecting evidence, and selective trust and distrust assigned to testimony in accordance with its congruence with desired beliefs.” (Williams 2023, 105)
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HOW MISTRUST,
DISINFORMATION, AND
MOTIVATED REASONING
MAKE US BELIEVE THINGS
THAT AREN'T TRUE

FALSE

JOE PIERRE MD

1. WHY WE ADOPT THEM

CONSPIRACY THEORIES:

- “Belief in conspiracy theories (BCT) can be understood as a result of mistrusting conventional knowledge and authoritative accounts (‘epistemic mistrust’) along with a biased appraisal of false counter-narratives (‘misinformation processing’)” (Pierre 2020, 617).
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1. WHY WE ADOPT THEM

CONSPIRACY THEORIES:

Implicated cognitive biases:

- Seeing patterns and meaning in the environment (van Prooijen, Douglas, & de Inocencio, 2018)
 - Hypersensitive agency detection (Douglas et al, 2016)
 - Perceptual and attentional biases (Van Elk 2015)
 - High needs for cognitive closure (Marchlewska, Cichocka, & Kossowska, 2018)
 - High need to feel unique (Imhoff & Lamberty, 2017)
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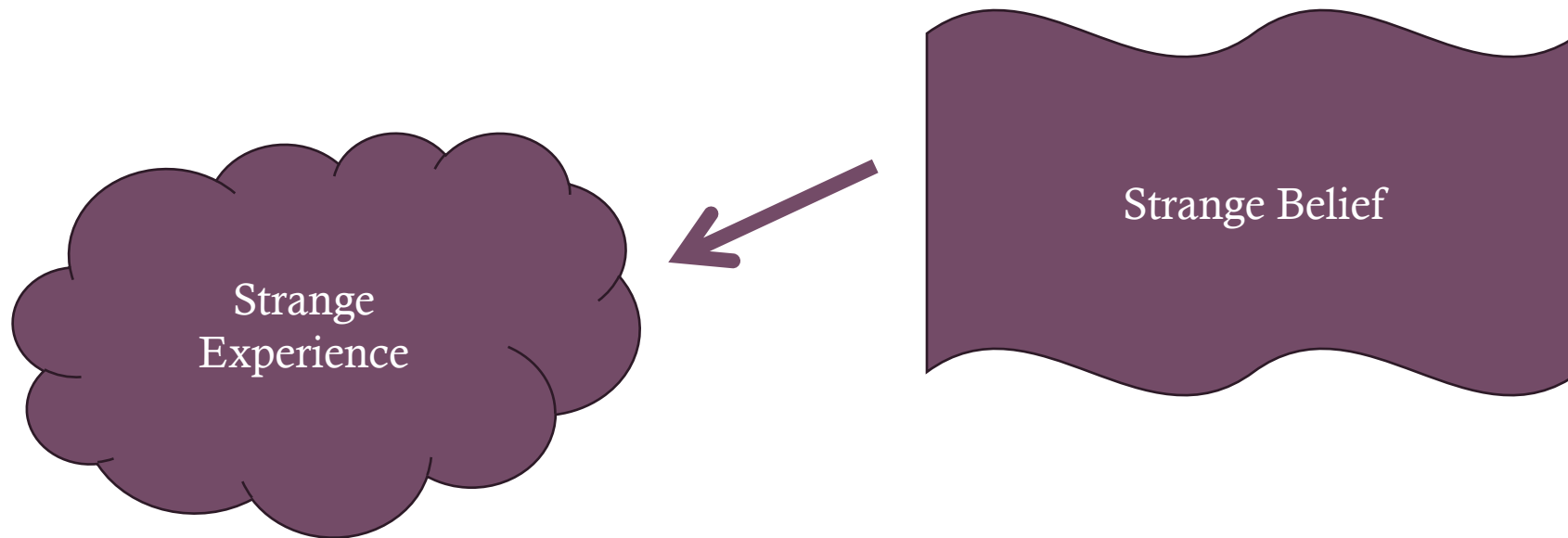
1. WHY WE ADOPT THEM

- **DELUSIONS**
- Gets more complicated, but biases are nevertheless often implicated.

[DELUSIONS]

- Empiricist vs Rationalist accounts of delusion formation

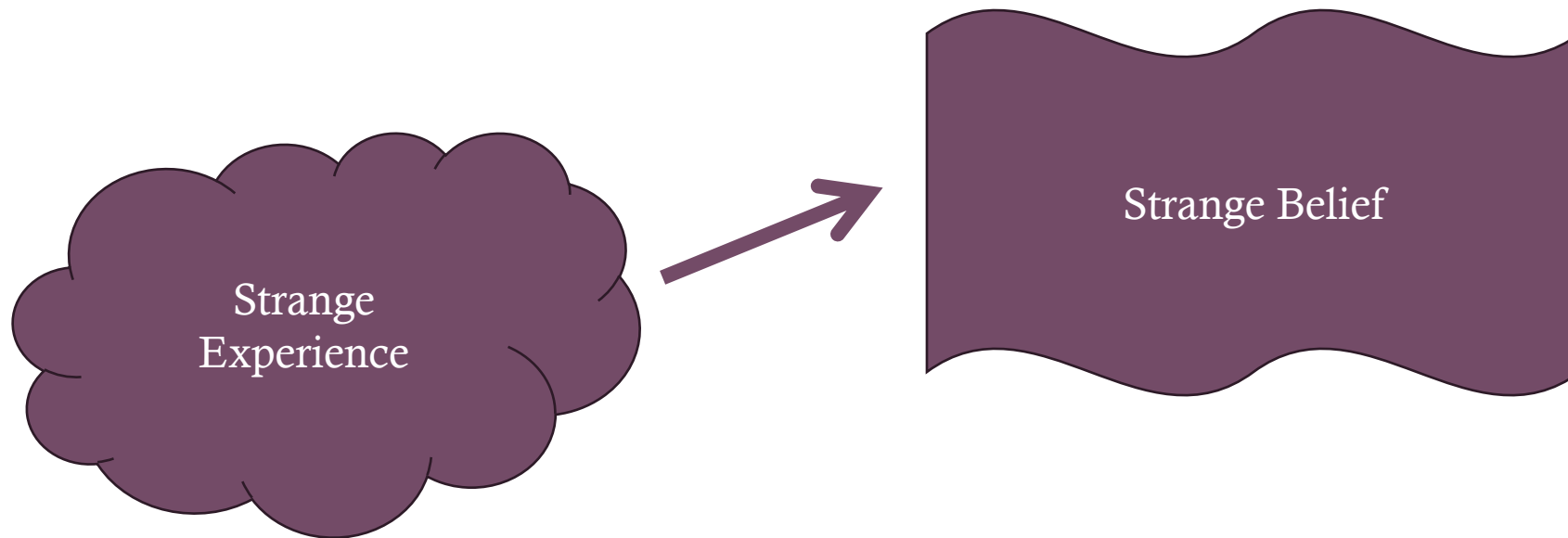
Rationalist accounts: Top-down model where the strange belief comes first, and causes the strange experience:



[DELUSIONS]

- Empiricist vs Rationalist accounts of delusion formation

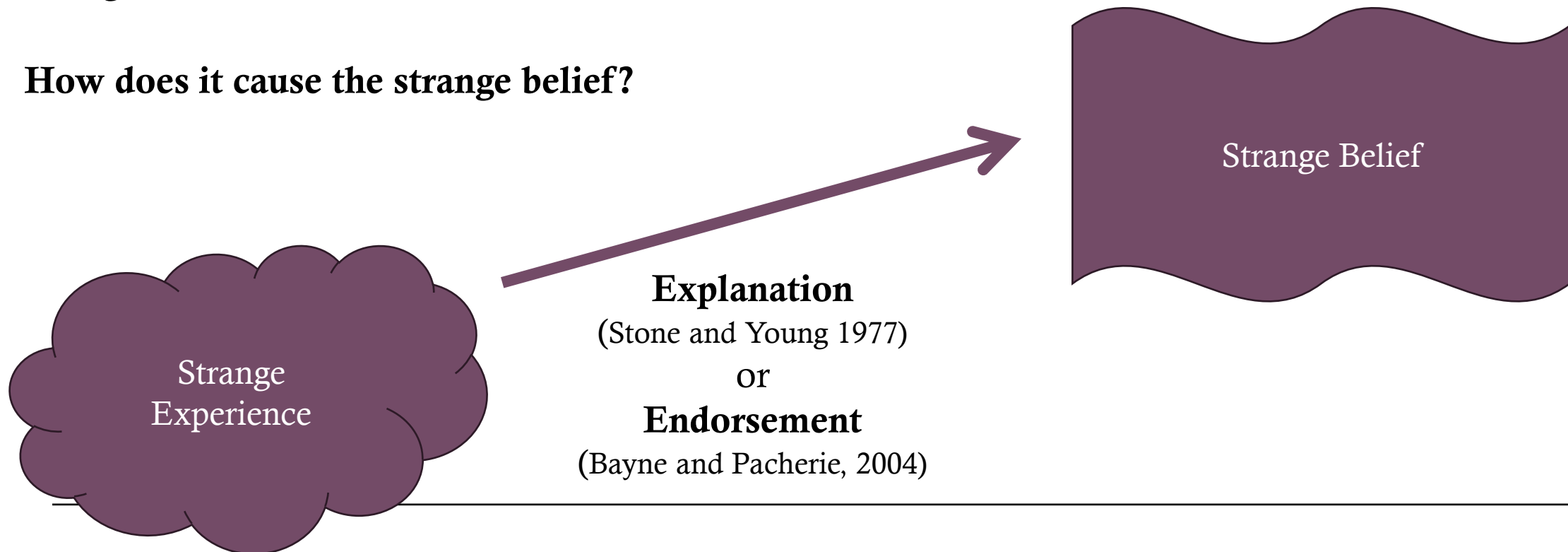
Empiricist accounts: Bottom-up model where the strange experience comes first, and causes the strange belief:



[DELUSIONS]

Empiricist accounts: Bottom-up model where the strange experience comes first, and causes the strange belief.

How does it cause the strange belief?



1. WHY WE ADOPT THEM

- **DELUSIONS**

- One factor vs Two Factor Accounts
 - Second factor: To explain why the strange belief is *adopted* and *maintained*.
 - “a loss of the ability to reject a candidate for belief on the grounds of its implausibility and its inconsistency with everything else that the patient knows” (Davies et al 2001, 149)
 - **Second factor** is usually a reasoning bias or deficit:
 - Attributional biases, data-gathering biases, evidence-type biases
 - Schizophrenia:
 - Jumping to conclusions, bias against discomformatory evidence, liberal acceptance, testimonial biases (Flores 2025)
 - An agent’s inner states are hugely relevant to what they come to believe.
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2. WHY BELIEVE HORRIBLE THINGS?

All these biases revolve around protecting a 'favoured' belief – but it's still not clear how and why people come to 'favour' and protect such unpleasant beliefs.

Recognising that the reasoning biases are a *secondary* stage after certain emotional experiences, actually applies back up the chain through conspiracy theories to 'everyday' beliefs and biases.

3. BELIEVING WHAT RESONATES

- Sometimes, we believe ideas on the basis of them **resonating**.
 - By resonating, I mean that **an idea identifies, explains, justifies or expresses some pre-existing existential feeling that the agent has**.
 - **Existential feelings**: Sense of practical possibilities, of being-in-the-world, of reality, of belonging, of interpersonal relatedness (Ratcliffe 2008)
 - **Phenomenal Character**:
 - Having an ‘A-ha!’ moment (Van de Cruys et al 2024)
 - Seduction of Clarity (Nguyen 2021)
 - Cognitive closure and satisfaction “Finding an explanation for something is accompanied by a satisfaction that goes beyond the merely cognitive” (Gopnik 2000, 311)
 - Hermeneutical justice/enlightenment; “No wonder that moments of its revelation can come as a life-changing flash of enlightenment” (Fricker 2007, 153)
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3. BELIEVING WHAT RESONATES

Theoretical payoffs

- Better explains empirical data of conspiracy theory beliefs.
 - *Abalakina-Paap et al (1999)*: feeling **alienated**, **powerless**, **anomie**, **hostile**, **unfairly disadvantaged**, **low in self-esteem**, **distrustful** of authority, and having an **external locus of control**.
 - *Goertzel (1994)*: “**anomia**, lack of interpersonal **trust**, and **insecurity** about employment”.
 - *Hofstadter (1965)*: feeling **politically powerless** and therefore **paranoid** about the outer world being sinister (1965, 39).
 - *Uscinski & Parent (2014)*: feeling ‘**defensive**’ about their social group as they see that it is **perceived as ‘low-status’**.
 - *Van Prooijen & Douglas (2017)*: Arise in the aftermath of **societal crises**.
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3. BELIEVING WHAT RESONATES

Theoretical payoffs

- These feelings **precede** the adoption of conspiracy beliefs:
 - *Van Prooijen & Böhm (2024)* found that **vaccine hesitancy precedes adopting anti-vaxx** conspiracy beliefs, and suggest that they are **seeking justifications** for those vaccine hesitant feelings, which they then find in anti-vaxx conspiracy theories.
 - *Bronstein et al (2022)* found that intention (not) to vaccinate and perceived (high) dangerousness of vaccination were **causes of belief** in anti-vaxx conspiracies – and not the opposite.
 - *Enders et al (2022)* found that conspiracy beliefs and misinformation were not always ‘an exogenous cause’ of vaccine hesitancy and refusal, but rather are a **downstream effect** (or, a co-occurring manifestation) of the psychological, social and political motivations which underlie the vaccine hesitancy and rejection.
 - In a broader political context, *Thomas et al (2025)* found that those who had antidemocratic, authoritarian sentiments were **subsequently** more likely to endorse conspiracy beliefs.
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3. BELIEVING WHAT RESONATES

Theoretical payoffs

- These feelings **precede** the adoption of conspiracy beliefs:
 - Those who *already* believe in some way, seek out and quickly accept fake news that supports the belief they already have (Mercier 2020, chapter 13; Miller et al 2016)
 - Kim & Kim (in press) found that conspiracy rumours about Obama being a Muslim were only accepted by those who *already* disliked Obama, and so were not the cause of any changed attitudes about Obama or voting intentions.
 - Murphy-Hollies 2026; conspiracy beliefs as post-hoc confabulations.
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3. BELIEVING WHAT RESONATES

Theoretical payoffs

- How compelling stories can create beliefs – as opposed to just imaginings
- Psychopathologies: depression [Vazard 2024] and delusions
 - Only some ideas can resonate (and resonate very strongly), given the anomalous feelings.
- Explains widespread evidence resistance across all these contexts
- Captures ‘wanting’ to believe unpleasant things

3. BELIEVING WHAT RESONATES

Explaining irrational beliefs

Motivated reasoning:

- “Information-sampling biases arise when individuals strategically alter which information they seek out and ignore in the interests of **finding rationalizations for desired beliefs** or **avoiding evidence in tension** with such desired beliefs. Information-processing biases arise when individuals interpret and process information in biased ways, and they include strategic variations in the time spent reasoning and deliberating, asymmetries in the standards required for accepting and rejecting evidence, and selective trust and distrust assigned to testimony in accordance with its congruence with desired beliefs.” (Williams 2023, 105)
 - How do we know, pre-reflectively, which evidence to attend to and which to dismiss?
 - The feeling which directs belief *precedes* belief formation, as opposed to arising as a consequence of adopting beliefs we ‘like’.
 - Irrational beliefs often do not update because the *feeling does not update*.
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3. BELIEVING WHAT RESONATES



Practical payoffs

- Improve people's existential predicaments more generally, in order to 'improve' certain beliefs.
- Improve availability of other sense-making ideas, which are also likely to resonate with individuals (health/science institutions often let people down!).

4. INTERPLAY OF VALENCES

- Valence of having an explanation $\neq$ Valence of the content of the explanation
- We are driven to make sense of our feelings.
 - Perhaps particularly keen to make sense of unpleasant feelings
- Trauma
 - 'all my fault' / 'I deserved it'.

CONCLUSIONS



A focus on biases and rationality, cannot explain the valence asymmetries we see in increasingly bizarre beliefs



We are driven to believe things which **resonate**.



This process helps us see that valence of having explanation, and valence of content, come apart.

THANK YOU!

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